



A ritual for the grief nobody sees

For the losses that had no funeral: a dream, a phase, a version of you.

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

*This guide addresses loss and grief. It
does not replace therapeutic support.
If your pain is greater than you can
bear, please seek professional help.*

1. The losses nobody recognizes

There are losses that have a funeral. The death of someone you love. Society recognizes them. There are rituals, condolences, permission to cry. People know you're suffering. They give you space. They give you time. They bring you flowers and hugs and casseroles of food.

But there are other losses. Losses with no funeral. Losses that no one sees, that no one names, that no one recognizes as a loss. And they are, often, the ones that hurt most.

The loss of a dream. The one you had at twenty that, slowly, was left behind. The career you wanted. The life you imagined. The place in the world you thought would be yours and that never came. No one dies when a dream dies. But something in you dies. And there are no condolences for dreams that go.

The loss of a phase. Your children have grown up. Your youth has passed. The body you had is no longer the body you have. The pregnancy you hoped for that didn't happen. The baby phase, which was so difficult and which, when it ended, left you with an emptiness you didn't expect. "You should be happy." "Now you have more freedom." But freedom tastes like loss. And no one understands why.

The loss of a version of yourself. The woman you were before you became a mother. The person you were before the burnout. The you before the diagnosis, the separation, the change. That woman no longer exists. And however many good things the new version of you may have, there is a grief for the previous one that is rarely processed. Because how do you grieve for yourself? How do you grieve for someone who is still alive?

The loss of a relationship that didn't end in death. Divorce. The drifting apart from a friend. The mother who is alive but emotionally absent. The father who was never who you needed him to be. These are ambiguous losses: the person is there, but what you had is not. And ambiguous grief may be the most difficult of all, because it has no resolution. There is no moment when you can say "it's over." It's always open. Always hurting. Always occupying space.

If you recognize any of these losses, I want you to know: your pain is real. Even if no one sees it. Even if no one brings you flowers. Even if you yourself think it's "an exaggeration" or "being dramatic." It isn't. It's grief. And grief deserves to be processed. Deserves space, time, attention. Deserves a ritual.

2. Why it hurts even when "nobody died"

The cruellest question you can hear when you're living one of these invisible losses is: "But nobody died, did they?"

No. Nobody died. And so you stay quiet. Because how do you justify a pain that has no dead person? How do you explain that you're grieving for something no one else recognizes as a loss?

Psychology has a name for this: unacknowledged grief (or disenfranchised grief). It's the grief that society doesn't validate. That has no associated rituals. That has no time off work. That has no flowers or masses or condolences. And because it's invisible, it's doubly painful: the loss hurts, and the loneliness of not being able to talk about it hurts too.

Unacknowledged grief happens more than you think. The woman who had a miscarriage and was told "don't worry, you'll have another." The couple who couldn't have children and is treated as if it were "a lifestyle choice." The person who retired and who should be "enjoying life" but who feels profoundly lost. The teenager who grieves childhood and is told "grow up, stop being a child." The immigrant who grieves their country and is told "at least you have a better life now."

All of these are real losses. All deserve grief. And all are silenced by a culture that tells us you can only truly suffer when the cause is "serious enough."

But pain doesn't work that way. Pain is not proportional to the cause, measured by an external criterion. Pain is proportional to what you lost, measured from within. And what you lost may have no name, no funeral, no social recognition, and still hurt with an intensity that surprises you.

If you feel this way, I want you to know: you are not exaggerating. You are feeling. And feeling is the most human thing you can do. What is missing is not a reason for your pain. What is missing is a ritual. A moment in which you can stop, recognize what you lost, honor it, and begin to say goodbye.

3. The ritual: an exercise in farewell and recognition

This ritual is not religious. It's not esoteric. It doesn't require candles, altars, or anything special. It only requires you, a moment of silence, and honesty.

It will happen in three parts: naming, honoring, and releasing.

Naming

Take a piece of paper. And write, in your own words, what you lost. Not in an abstract way. In a concrete way.

Don't write "I lost my youth." Write: "I lost the woman who danced in the kitchen without caring who was watching. I lost the energy that kept me up until two in the morning laughing with friends. I lost the body that ran without pain. I lost the freedom of having no responsibilities. I lost the certainty that the future would be brilliant."

Don't write "I lost my marriage." Write: "I lost Sunday mornings in bed with him. I lost the person who made me laugh like no one else could. I lost the dream of growing old beside someone. I lost my place in his

family. I lost my idea of what my life would be."

The more concrete, the more real. And the more real, the more the body can process it. Because the body doesn't process abstractions. It processes experiences. And in naming what you lost in detail, you are giving the body permission to feel what it has been holding.

Honoring

Now look at what you wrote. And honor it. Not with sadness, though sadness will come. With recognition. Say to each item on your list (out loud or in silence, whichever you prefer):

"I saw you. You existed. You were real. You were important to me. And I grieve that you are gone."

You don't need to say more. You don't need to explain why. You don't need to justify the pain. Simply recognize: this happened. This hurt. And I am allowing myself to feel the pain.

You may cry. You may feel a weight lifting from your chest. You may feel anger, or relief, or a mixture of everything. All of it is valid. All of it is part of the process.

Releasing

The last part is the most difficult. Not because it requires effort. Because it requires permission.

Take the paper where you wrote what you lost. And say (to yourself, to the paper, to the universe, to whoever you wish):

"I honor what was. And I let it go. Not because it doesn't matter. Because it can no longer stay. And I need space for what is to come."

Then do what you feel with the paper. You can keep it. You can tear it up. You can burn it (carefully). You can fold it and place it in a box that represents the past. The gesture matters. The gesture is the body doing what the mind alone cannot: closing a cycle.

This ritual is not a cure. It doesn't erase the pain. It doesn't "resolve" the grief. But it opens a door. The door to being able to continue without dragging behind you what can no longer be carried. To being able to remember without getting stuck. To being able to honor without repeating.

4. When the pain is greater

If in doing this ritual you feel the pain is too great, that it goes beyond what you can contain alone, that it submerges you, please stop. Close this guide. Take care of yourself. And seek someone who can be with you.

There are pains that need professional company. There are griefs that need more than a ritual on paper. They need therapy, accompanied time, someone who knows how to hold with you what you cannot hold alone. And seeking that help is not weakness. It's the most courageous and most loving decision you can make for yourself.

Grief has no deadline. It has no expiry date. And "moving on" doesn't mean forgetting. It means learning to carry what you lost in a way that doesn't crush you. That allows you to continue living, loving, feeling. With the loss, not despite it. Because the loss is part of you now. And integrating it is different from overcoming it.

5. Bridge: the work as a space for grief

If you feel this guide touched something in you, if you feel there is more grief to process than what fits in a ritual, I want you to know that my work (the writings on the site, the books, the spaces I created) was born, in large part, from grief. From grieving the versions of myself that were left behind. From grieving the people I lost. From grieving the dreams that didn't come true. And I discovered that writing, creating, giving form to what has no form, is one of the most powerful ways to grieve.

The Escola dos Véus was born from that place: the place where loss transforms, not into forgetting, but into understanding. At escoladosveus.space.

And if there is something creative in you that wants to come out (a word, a drawing, a sound, a gesture), Infonte is where creativity and self-knowledge meet. At infonte.viviannedossantos.com.

But for now, stay with the ritual. Return to it when you need to. And remember: every loss you felt truly deserves to be honored. Even the ones nobody saw. Even the ones that had no funeral.

This guide is a self-knowledge resource. It does not constitute therapeutic advice. If you are in acute suffering, if grief paralyzes you, if you have thoughts of giving up, seek professional support. In Portugal: SNS 24 (808 24 24 24).

© 2026 Vivianne dos Santos · viviannedossantos.com



© 2026 Vivianne dos Santos

viviannedossantos.com

freeme.viviannedossantos.com